

How castles were built

Building a castle required many skilled workers. A master mason drew up plans and supervised the work, and less senior masons carried out the building. Carpenters did the woodwork, and metalworkers made hinges and door fasteners. In a large castle, some specialists stayed on permanently to do the maintenance work.

Wood and earthwork

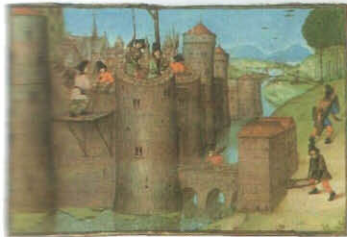
The Normans chose a site where there was a water supply, built a mound and a wooden castle on top, and surrounded the structure with a wooden fence, or palisade. Most were replaced with stone constructions.



Motte-and-bailey

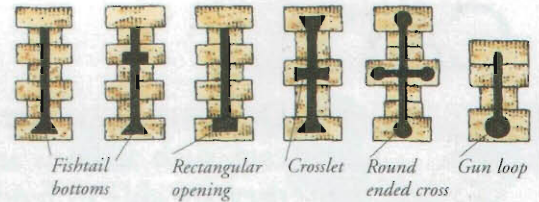
Stonework

Building a stone castle took decades, but the result was a strong castle that would withstand attack well. The important structures, such as the outer walls, mural towers, and keep, were all made of stone. Buildings in the castle courtyard were still made of timber and had thatched roofs.



Windows

Most castle windows were narrow or cross-shaped slits. They usually had a large alcove on the inside of the wall. This allowed an archer to stand to one side and avoid missiles while preparing to shoot.



Arrow slits developed that were large enough for a defender to shoot an arrow out, but too small for an attacker's missiles. Later, the gun loop developed with a circular hole to fit a gun barrel.

Edward I

In the early years of his reign, Edward I (r.1272–1307) conquered Wales, and built an "iron ring" of castles in strategic Welsh towns to keep the country under his control. Many of these Welsh castles, such as Harlech and Beaumaris, were built on the concentric plan, which meant they had both inner and outer walls for defence. Concentric castles were very difficult to attack successfully.



Asian and African castles

Castles have been built in many different places. There was a strong tradition of castle-building in the Islamic world, and medieval soldiers took Muslim ideas about fortification to western Europe when they returned from the crusades.

Himeji Castle, Japan

Seventeenth-century Japan had a feudal system similar to that of medieval Europe, and Japanese lords also lived in castles. Tall towers with pagoda-like roofs had narrow window openings through which soldiers could shoot. The towers were surrounded by courtyards and walls.



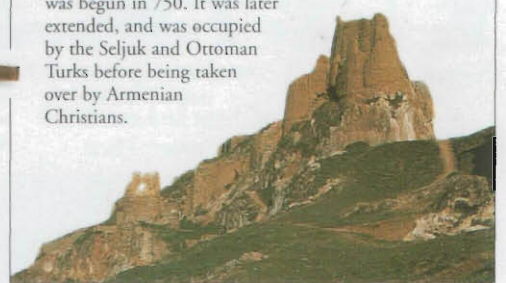
Fasilidas Castle, Ethiopia

The central stronghold shows many features in common with western castles, including thick walls of stone, round corner towers, and battlements. The remains of the outer curtain wall can be seen in the foreground to the right.



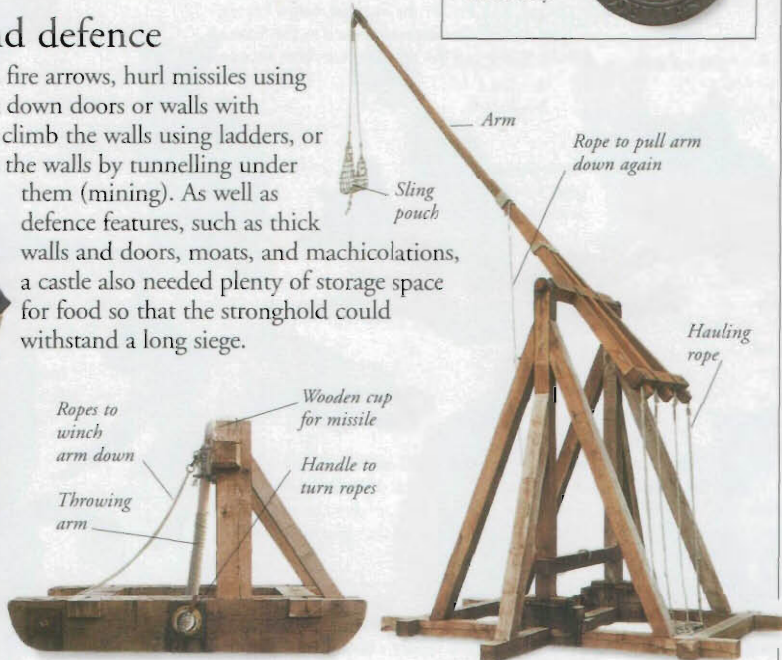
Van Castle, Turkey

Built on a rocky outcrop, Van Castle was begun in 750. It was later extended, and was occupied by the Seljuk and Ottoman Turks before being taken over by Armenian Christians.



Attack and defence

Attackers could fire arrows, hurl missiles using catapults, break down doors or walls with battering rams, climb the walls using ladders, or try to demolish the walls by tunnelling under them (mining). As well as defence features, such as thick walls and doors, moats, and machicolations, a castle also needed plenty of storage space for food so that the stronghold could withstand a long siege.



Crossbow

Crossbows were powerful but slow to reload. Despite this they could be useful in defending castles, where they could be reloaded behind the safety of the stone walls.

Catapult

The soldiers used a handle attached to a rope (made from a skein of twisted rope) to winch the throwing arm down. They then released it, and the arm flew up, releasing its missile, usually a rock, from a wooden cup.

Traction trebuchet

This siege engine was like a giant catapult. When soldiers pulled down on the ropes, the end of the arm flew upward, and the sling opened to release a missile, which usually weighed about 45–90 kg (100–200 lb).

Pfalzgrafenstein, Germany

1338 Many German castles are built on the Rhine because of the river's importance as a trade route.



Bodiam, England



1385 Bodiam Castle has a curtain wall around a courtyard, which contains the hall and chapel.

Real de Manzanares, Spain

1416 By this time many French castles, such as Saumur on the River Loire, have conical towers, strong defensive walls, and luxurious rooms.



1435 The elaborate Real de Manzanares is built.

1642 In Traquair, a Scottish tower-house, turrets and battlements are more for decoration than defence.



1600s Many castles were built by local lords in Japan, like Himeji.

Traquair House, Scotland

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